



The AI Agent Design Canvas

Design the person first. Then the agent that serves them.

2 hours

AI • Agents • Product

A3 landscape

v1 • 2026

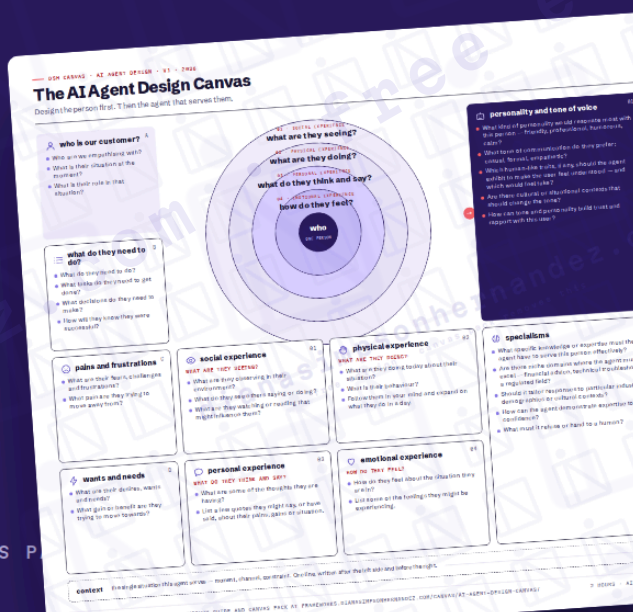
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[Free A3 PDF + quick guide](#)

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— WHAT IT IS

What this canvas does

Most AI agents are specified from the model outwards: pick a model, write a system prompt, bolt on tools, then discover in testing that nobody wanted to talk to it. This canvas reverses the order.

— WHEN TO USE IT

- Before writing the first system prompt for a customer-facing agent, assistant or copilot.
- When an existing agent has good accuracy and poor adoption — usually a personality or task-priority problem, not a model problem.
- As the shared specification between product, design and engineering, so the prompt, the UI and the integrations are built from one document.

— WHO IT IS FOR

Teams specifying a customer-facing AI agent, assistant or copilot — before the first prompt is written. 2 hours with three to eight people.

— BOX BY BOX

The short version

01 · WHO IS OUR CUSTOMER? · WHAT DO THEY NEED TO DO? · PAINS · WANTS

Run the left column as you would the Empathy Canvas: one person, their tasks and success criterion, what they fear and what they want.

03 · CONTEXT

Write the single situation the agent serves. One line.

05 · CORE TASKS

List the tasks in the order they relieve the pains on the left. Mark each as inform, decide or execute.

07 · ACTIONS AND APIS REQUIRED

For each task: the action, the integration behind it, the real-time data it needs, and what happens when it fails.

02 · THE FOUR RINGS

Outside in: what they see, what they do, what they think and say, how they feel. Refuse to write feelings until behaviour is down.

04 · PERSONALITY AND TONE OF VOICE

Choose the personality this person would trust in this moment. Name the traits to show, the ones to avoid, and how tone changes with their state.

06 · SPECIALISMS

The knowledge it must have, the domains it must excel in, how it shows expertise, and what it must refuse or hand to a human.

The Canvas Pack (£49) has the full walkthrough for every canvas — what good looks like for each box, a worked example, the agenda and the mistakes — plus clean A3 PDFs and 4K PNGs.
frameworks.dianasimpsonhernandez.com/canvas/